

All the Right Keys

Keyboards are the most used components of your PC. We tested six of them to find which one deserves your touch

The days of the 101-key keyboard are long gone, with newer multimedia keyboards sporting as many as 22 hotkeys apart from aesthetic and ergonomic designs. The price of these keyboards is now less than Rs 600, whereas a regular keyboard can be purchased for as less as Rs 300. We tested six keyboards from Microsoft, Odyssey, Logitech and Samsung.

Digit Test Process

We tested the keyboard on a system with a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz processor, an MSI MAX2BLR motherboard, 256 MB DDRAM and a 40 GB Seagate Barracuda drive. The OS used was Windows XP Professional. The keyboards were tested on four primary parameters: Features, Ergonomics, Build quality and Value for money. Each parameter was allotted a 25 per cent weightage. The weightages allotted to each parameter was used to calculate the overall scores.

Features: The interface of the keyboard was the first criterion of testing. A USB keyboard scored higher than a PS/2 one. Next up was the number of hotkeys on the keyboard. The greater this number, the higher it scored. Finally, some keyboards come with integrated trackballs and other mouse controls—such devices scored higher over those that did not feature these.

Ergonomics: Comfort is paramount when judging a keyboard. The ergonomics that a keyboard offered was evaluated on the basis of several factors—the comfort it provided while typing, the layout of the keys on the device, the tactile feedback while typing and the presence or absence of a palm rest were the factors considered.

Build quality: A keyboard should be built to last, since the device is in constant touch with its user and use and abuse are part of its job description. Keyboards were thrown against each other on the basis of sturdiness and the stability of the buttons and of the unit as a whole.

P R O D U C T S	
LOGITECH NEWTOUCH MULTIMEDIA KEYBOARD	
MICROSOFT MULTIMEDIA KEYBOARD	
ODYSSEY OD2001 IR	
ODYSSEY OD2001 M1	
SAMSUNG MULTIMEDIA KEYBOARD SEM-M2A	
SAMSUNG PC KEYBOARD	

Logitech NewTouch Multimedia Keyboard

Features: 12 hotkeys, PS/2 interface, package includes a palm rest
Price: Rs 875 Contact: Rashi Peripherals Phone: 022-28260258
E-mail: ho@rptechindia.com Web site: www.logitech.com

The New iTouch Multimedia Keyboard from Logitech is easy on the eyes and offers a great typing experience. It has a total of 12 hotkeys that allow faster Web surfing and greater efficiency when working with applications. The keys are soft on the fingers and a delight to work with, complete with silent keystrokes and an excellent build quality. Accompanying the keyboard is a driver CD to configure the shortcut keys and a Quick Start Guide. The keyboard is priced at Rs 875, which brings it under the budget of most users and also makes it a very good option for both office and home users.



Logitech Newtouch	
Features	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ B+
Build quality	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Ergonomics	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Value for money	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
OVERALL	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶

Microsoft Multimedia Keyboard

Features: 16 hotkeys, PS/2 interface, package includes a palm rest
Price: Rs 1,606 Contact: Microsoft Corporation India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 011-26292640 E-mail: connect@microsoft.com
Web site: www.microsoft.com

Testing Microsoft's MultiMedia keyboard was a sheer delight. It has a very intelligent placement of the keys and features a new design with rounded contours and a two-tone finish with a blue body and white keys. The multimedia keys are located at the top, along with keys for accessing your e-mail, an instant messenger, the Media Player, the My Documents folder, etc. Apart from these, an F-lock key allows the user alternate uses for the function keys such as open a new Word document, send mail, etc. The keyboard pegs are well designed and sturdy enough to take the load of your palm. The provided software works seamlessly and hassle-free. With a price tag of Rs 1,606, this keyboard from Microsoft is one of the best around.



Microsoft Multimedia	
Features	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ B+
Build quality	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Ergonomics	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Value for money	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
OVERALL	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶